

drop-cover-hold-drill

The Drop, Cover, Hold On Drill™

Train the 90-Second Reflex Until It's Automatic — For Every Location You'll Actually Be In

Why this worksheet exists: During an earthquake, you do not have time to think. The households that come through with the least injury are the ones who had already turned “drop, cover, hold on” into a physical reflex — trained, not just read about. This tool gives you the exact move for every location you're likely to be in, plus a real drill script to run with your family, timed, until it's automatic.

How to run it: Read the location-specific moves once. Then run the physical drill with your household — actually get down on the floor, actually get under the table, actually hold the position for 60 seconds. Do this quarterly (Tool #8 tracks it).

The master rule, in five words: Drop. Cover. Hold on. Wherever.

Part 1 — The Universal Move (memorize this)

1. **DROP** to the ground, wherever you are, immediately — do not wait to see if it's “a big one,” do not try to reach another room.
2. **COVER** your head and neck with your arms, and get under/against something sturdy: a sturdy table or desk, or against an interior wall away from windows, mirrors, and anything that could fall.
3. **HOLD ON** to whatever you're under (or hold your own head/neck) until the shaking completely stops. Expect it to feel long — most quakes last under 60 seconds, but adrenaline makes it feel much longer.

The three myths to unlearn immediately: - □ **“Run outside.”** The leading cause of quake injury is being struck by falling or flying objects *inside*. You are safer dropping in place than sprinting for a door. - □ **“Stand in a doorway.”** Modern doorways are not stronger than the rest of the room, and standing in one exposes you to a swinging door and passing debris. - □ **“The triangle of life” (lie next to furniture, not under it).** This theory is not supported by search-and-rescue data or emergency management agencies. Get UNDER sturdy furniture, or cover against an interior wall — official guidance, worldwide, is drop-cover-hold, not “triangle of life.”

Part 2 — Location-Specific Moves (know all of these)

If you're indoors (home, office, school)

- Drop, get under a sturdy desk/table if one is within a step or two.
- If no sturdy furniture is near, drop against an interior wall, away from windows, mirrors, tall furniture, and anything hanging.
- Cover your head/neck with your arms either way. Hold on until shaking stops.

If you're in bed

- **Stay in bed.** Grab a pillow to cover your head/neck and hold on. Getting up in the dark, disoriented, with glass potentially on the floor, is more dangerous than staying put — unless something heavy is positioned to fall directly on the bed (which is why Tool #2's bedroom audit matters).

If you're outdoors

- Move away from buildings, trees, streetlights, and power lines if you can do so immediately and safely — falling facades and power lines are the outdoor risk.
- Drop in an open area and cover your head/neck. Hold on until shaking stops.

If you're driving

- Pull over as quickly and safely as possible, avoiding overpasses, bridges, buildings, trees, and power lines.
- Stop the car, put it in park, and stay inside with your seatbelt on until the shaking stops — a car offers real protection from falling debris.

If you're in a high-rise

- Same universal move: drop, cover, hold on, away from windows and exterior walls.
- **Do not use the elevator during or immediately after.** Expect fire alarms and sprinklers to activate — this is normal, not necessarily a fire.
- After shaking stops, use stairs to evacuate if instructed, checking each landing.

If you're at the beach or near a coastline

- After the shaking stops, if you're in a coastal area, move to higher ground immediately — a strong coastal earthquake can generate a tsunami with very little warning. Do not wait for an official alert if the shaking was strong and you're near the shore; move inland/uphill first, confirm after.

If you use a wheelchair or have limited mobility

- Lock the wheelchair brakes, stay seated, and cover your head/neck with your arms or whatever is available.
 - If a companion is present, they should drop and cover near you rather than trying to move you during the shaking.
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Part 3 — The Family Drill Script (run this, out loud, timed)

Setup (2 minutes): Gather the household. Explain you're running a real drill, not just talking about it. Assign one person as the "caller."

The drill (repeat 3 times, different scenarios):

1. Caller shouts: **"EARTHQUAKE! DROP, COVER, HOLD ON!"**
2. Everyone physically drops to the floor immediately, gets under/against the nearest sturdy furniture or interior wall, covers head/neck, and holds the position.
3. Caller starts a 60-second timer out loud: "Shaking... shaking... still shaking..."
4. At 60 seconds, caller says **"Shaking has stopped. Check yourself, then check your neighbor."**
5. Everyone does a real self-check (any pain? can you move?) then checks the person nearest them.
6. Caller says **"Move to the family meeting point."** Everyone physically walks there (see Tool #5 for your meeting point).

Run this scenario 3 times, in 3 different rooms of the house, so it's not tied to one specific spot. Then run it once outdoors and once in the car if possible.

Timing goal: everyone should be down, covered, and holding within **3 seconds** of the call. If it takes longer, run it again. This is the entire point of a drill — building a reflex fast enough to matter.

Part 4 — Special Notes for Kids

- Make the drill a game the first few times ("freeze like a turtle!") — younger kids respond better to a fun framing than a scary one.
 - Practice the sound of a real earthquake early warning alert (many phone systems have a test/preview tone) so it's not a jump-scare the first time they hear it.
 - Teach kids that if they're at school, they should follow their teacher's instructions — schools run their own drills, and consistency matters more than a different home-taught version.
 - Reassure them explicitly: **"You know exactly what to do. That's why we practice."** Confidence reduces panic more than any single fact you can tell them.
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The Verdict Sheet

- **Drill run date:** _____
 - **Average reaction time (call to fully covered):** _____ seconds
 - **Rooms tested:** _____ of 3+
 - **Outdoor drill run?** Y / N
 - **Car drill run?** Y / N
 - **Next scheduled drill (90 days out):** _____
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Pro Tips From the Field

1. **Drill without warning once a quarter.** A surprise drill (say, during dinner) tests the real reflex far better than an announced one.
 2. **Drill in the dark once.** Power is often out after a real quake — knowing the floor plan blind matters.
 3. **Update the drill as kids grow.** A toddler’s “get under the table” becomes a teenager’s full location-specific repertoire — re-teach as they age.
 4. **Post the universal move somewhere visible** — a fridge magnet or laminated card by the door reinforces it between drills.
 5. **The drill is the highest-ROI 15 minutes in this entire system.** Everything else prepares your supplies. This prepares your body’s automatic response — and that’s what actually happens in the first 90 seconds.
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Your Next Step

You have the drill. Now execute: run it this weekend, all three room variations, timed. Then move to the **Family Emergency Plan (Tool #5)** to lock in your meeting point and communication protocol — because the drill gets you through the shaking, and the plan gets your family back together afterward.

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